

D'Artagnan, therefore, had passed the two days and the two nights of the voyage close to the coffin, alone with the general, offering him wine and food, which the latter had refused, and constantly endeavouring to reassure him upon the destiny which awaited him at the end of this singular captivity. Two pistols on the table and his naked sword made D'Artagnan easy with regard to indiscretions from without.

When once at Scheveningen he had felt completely reassured. His men greatly dreaded any conflict with the lords of the soil. He had, besides, interested in his cause him who had morally served him as lieutenant, and whom we have seen reply to the name of Menneville. The latter, not being a vulgar spirit, had more to risk than the others, because he had more conscience. He believed in a future in the service of D'Artagnan, and consequently would have allowed himself to be cut to pieces, rather than violate the order given by his leader. Thus it was that, once landed, it was to him that D'Artagnan had confided the care of the chest and the general's breathing. It was he, too, he had ordered to have the chest brought by the seven men as soon as he should hear the triple whistle. We have seen that the lieutenant obeyed. The coffer once in the house, D'Artagnan dismissed his men with a gracious smile, saying, 'Messieurs, you have rendered a great service to King Charles II, who in less than six weeks will be king of England. Your gratification will then be doubled. Return to the boat and wait for me.' Upon which they departed with such shouts of joy as terrified even the dog himself.

D'Artagnan had caused the coffer to be brought as far as the king's ante-chamber. He then, with great care, closed the door of this ante-chamber, after which he opened the coffer, and said to the general:

'General, I have a thousand excuses to make to you; my manner of acting has not been worthy of such a man as you, I know very well; but I wished you to take me for the captain of a bark. And then England is a very inconvenient country for transports. I hope, therefore, you will take all that into consideration. But now, general, you are at liberty to get up and walk.' This said, he cut the bonds which fastened the arms and hands of the general. The latter got up, and then sat down with the countenance of a man who expects death. D'Artagnan opened the door of Charles's study, and said, 'Sire, here is your enemy, M. Monk; I promised myself to perform this service for your majesty. It is done; now order as

you please. M. Monk,' added he, turning towards the prisoner, 'you are in the presence of his majesty Charles II, sovereign lord of Great Britain.'

Monk raised towards the prince his coldly stoical look, and replied: 'I know no king of Great Britain; I recognize even here no one worthy of bearing the name of gentleman: for it is in the name of King Charles II that an emissary, whom I took for an honest man, came and laid an infamous snare for me. I have fallen into that snare; so much the worse for me. Now, you the tempter,' said he to the king; 'you the executor,' said he to D'Artagnan; 'remember what I am about to say to you: you have my body, you may kill it, and I advise you to do so, for you shall never have my mind or my will. And now, ask me not a single word, as from this moment I will not open my mouth even to cry out. I have said.'

And he pronounced these words with the savage, invincible resolution of the most mortified Puritan. D'Artagnan looked at his prisoner like a man who knows the value of every word, and who fixes that value according to the accent with which it has been pronounced.

'The fact is,' said he, in a whisper to the king, 'the general is an obstinate man; he would not take a mouthful of bread, nor swallow a drop of wine, during the two days of our voyage. But as from this moment it is your majesty who must decide his fate, I wash my hands of him.'

Monk, erect, pale, and resigned, waited with his eyes fixed and his arms folded. D'Artagnan turned towards him. 'You will please to understand perfectly,' said he, 'that your speech, otherwise very fine, does not suit anybody, not even yourself. His majesty wished to speak to you, you refused an interview; why, now that you are face to face, that you are here by a force independent of your will, why do you confine yourself to the rigours which I consider useless and absurd? Speak! what the devil! speak, if only to say "No."'

Monk did not uncloset his lips; Monk did not turn his eyes; Monk stroked his moustache with a thoughtful air, which announced that matters were going on badly.

During all this time Charles II had fallen into a profound reverie. For the first time he found himself face to face with Monk; with the man he had so much desired to see; and, with that peculiar glance which God has given to eagles and kings, he had fathomed the abyss of his heart. He beheld Monk, then, resolved positively to die rather than speak, which

was not to be wondered at in so considerable a man, the wound in whose mind must at the moment have been cruel. Charles II formed, on the instant, one of those resolutions upon which an ordinary man risks his life, a general his fortune, and a king his kingdom. ‘Monsieur,’ said he to Monk, ‘you are perfectly right upon certain points; I do not, therefore, ask you to answer me, but to listen to me.’

There was a moment’s silence, during which the king looked at Monk, who remained impassible.

‘You have made me just now a painful reproach, monsieur,’ continued the king; ‘you said that one of my emissaries had been to Newcastle to lay a snare for you, and that, parenthetically, cannot be understood by M. d’Artagnan here, and to whom, before everything, I owe sincere thanks for his generous, his heroic devotion.’

D’Artagnan bowed with respect; Monk took no notice.

‘For M. d’Artagnan—and observe, M. Monk, I do not say this to excuse myself—for M. d’Artagnan,’ continued the king, ‘went to England of his free will, without interest, without orders, without hope, like a true gentleman as he is, to render a service to an unfortunate king, and to add to the illustrious actions of an existence, already so well filled, one glorious deed more.’

D’Artagnan coloured a little, and coughed to keep his countenance. Monk did not stir.

‘You do not believe what I tell you, M. Monk,’ continued the king. ‘I can understand that,—such proofs of devotion are so rare, that their reality may well be put in doubt.’

‘Monsieur would do wrong not to believe you, sire,’ cried D’Artagnan: ‘for that which your majesty has said is the exact truth, and the truth so exact that it seems, in going to fetch the general, I have done something which sets everything wrong. In truth, if it be so, I am in despair.’

‘Monsieur d’Artagnan,’ said the king, pressing the hand of the musketeer, ‘you have obliged me as much as if you had promoted the success of my cause, for you have revealed to me an unknown friend, to whom I shall ever be grateful, and whom I shall always love.’ And the king pressed his hand cordially. ‘And,’ continued he, bowing to Monk, ‘an enemy whom I shall henceforth esteem at his proper value.’

Chapter XXIX

Fear He Has Placed his Money and That of Planchet in the Sinking Fund



HE king could not overcome his surprise, and looked sometimes at the smiling face of the musketeer, and sometimes at the dark window which opened into the night. But before he had fixed his ideas, eight of D’Artagnan’s men, for two had remained to take care of the bark, brought to the house, where Parry received him, that object of an oblong form, which, for the moment, inclosed the destinies of England. Before he left Calais, D’Artagnan had had made in that city a sort of coffin, large and deep enough for a man to turn in it at his ease. The bottom and sides, properly upholstered, formed a bed sufficiently soft to prevent the rolling of the ship turning this kind of cage into a rat-trap. The little grating, of which D’Artagnan had spoken to the king, like the visor of the helmet, was placed opposite to the man’s face. It was so constructed that, at the least cry, a sudden pressure would stifle that cry, and, if necessary, him who had uttered that cry.

D’Artagnan was so well acquainted with his crew and his prisoner, that during the whole voyage he had been in dread of two things: either that the general would prefer death to this sort of imprisonment, and would smother himself by endeavouring to speak, or that his guards would allow themselves to be tempted by the offers of the prisoner, and put him, D’Artagnan, into the box instead of Monk.

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The eyes of the Puritan flashed, but only once, and his countenance, for an instant, illuminated by that flash, resumed its somber impassibility.

‘Then, Monsieur d’Artagnan,’ continued Charles, ‘this is what was about to happen: M. le Comte de la Fère, who you know, I believe, has set out for Newcastle.’

‘What, Athos!’ exclaimed D’Artagnan.

‘Yes, that was his nom de guerre, I believe. The Comte de la Fère had then set out for Newcastle, and was going, perhaps, to bring the general to hold a conference with me or with those of my party, when you violently, as it appears, interfered with the negotiation.’

‘*Mordieux!*’ replied D’Artagnan, ‘he entered the camp the very evening in which I succeeded in getting into it with my fishermen—’

An almost imperceptible frown on the brow of Monk told D’Artagnan that he had surmised rightly.

‘Yes, yes,’ muttered he; ‘I thought I knew his person; I even fancied I knew his voice. Unlucky wretch that I am! Oh! sire, pardon me! I thought I had so successfully steered my bark.’

‘There is nothing ill in it, sir,’ said the king, ‘except that the general accuses me of having laid a snare for him, which is not the case. No, general, those are not the arms which I contemplated employing with you, as you will soon see. In the meanwhile, when I give you my word upon the honour of a gentleman, believe me, sir, believe me! Now, Monsieur d’Artagnan, a word with you, if you please.’

‘I listen on my knees, sire.’

‘You are truly at my service, are you not?’

‘Your majesty has seen that I am, too much so.’

‘That is well; from a man like you one word suffices. In addition to that word you bring actions. General, have the goodness to follow me. Come with us, M. d’Artagnan.’

D’Artagnan, considerably surprised, prepared to obey. Charles II went out, Monk followed him, D’Artagnan followed Monk. Charles took the path by which D’Artagnan had come to his abode; the fresh sea breezes soon caressed the faces of the three nocturnal travellers, and, at fifty paces from the little gate which Charles opened, they found themselves upon the down in the face of the ocean, which, having ceased to rise, reposed upon the shore like a wearied monster. Charles II walked pensively along,

his head hanging down and his hand beneath his cloak. Monk followed him, with crossed arms and an uneasy look. D'Artagnan came last, with his hand on the hilt of his sword.

'Where is the boat in which you came, gentlemen?' said Charles to the musketeer.

'Yonder, sire; I have seven men and an officer waiting me in that little bark which is lighted by a fire.'

'Yes, I see; the boat is drawn upon the sand; but you certainly did not come from Newcastle in that frail bark?'

'No, sire; I freighted a felucca, at my own expense, which is at anchor within cannon-shot of the downs. It was in that felucca we made the voyage.'

'Sir,' said the king to Monk, 'you are free.'

However firm his will, Monk could not suppress an exclamation. The king added an affirmative motion of his head, and continued: 'We shall waken a fisherman of the village, who will put his boat to sea immediately, and will take you back to any place you may command him. M. d'Artagnan here will escort your honour. I place M. d'Artagnan under the safeguard of your loyalty, M. Monk.'

Monk allowed a murmur of surprise to escape him, and D'Artagnan a profound sigh. The king, without appearing to notice either, knocked against the deal trellis which inclosed the cabin of the principal fisherman inhabiting the down.

'Hey! Keyser!' cried he, 'awake!'

'Who calls me?' asked the fisherman.

'I, Charles the king.'

'Ah, my lord!' cried Keyser, rising ready dressed from the sail in which he slept, as people sleep in a hammock. 'What can I do to serve you?'

'Captain Keyser,' said Charles, 'you must set sail immediately. Here is a traveller who wishes to freight your bark, and will pay you well; serve him well.' And the king drew back a few steps to allow Monk to speak to the fisherman.

'I wish to cross over into England,' said Monk, who spoke Dutch enough to make himself understood.

'This minute,' said the patron, 'this very minute, if you wish it.'

'But will that be long?' said Monk.

'And having taken him on the causeway of Newcastle, I bring him to your majesty,' said D'Artagnan, simply.

'You bring him to me!' cried the king, almost indignant at what he considered a mystification.

'Yes, sire,' replied D'Artagnan, in the same tone, 'I bring him to you; he is down below yonder, in a large chest pierced with holes, so as to allow him to breathe.'

'Good God!'

'Oh! don't be uneasy, sire, we have taken the greatest possible care of him. He comes in good state, and in perfect condition. Would your majesty please to see him, to talk with him, or to have him thrown into the sea?'

'Oh, heavens!' repeated Charles, 'oh, heavens! do you speak the truth, monsieur? Are you not insulting me with some unworthy joke? You have accomplished this unheard-of act of audacity and genius—impossible!'

'Will your majesty permit me to open the window?' said D'Artagnan, opening it.

The king had not time to reply yes or no. D'Artagnan gave a shrill and prolonged whistle, which he repeated three times through the silence of the night.

'There!' said he, 'he will be brought to your majesty.'

‘Oh! I know very well, sire, that etiquette will not allow kings to be questioned. I hope, however, presently you will pardon my want of etiquette. Your majesty added that, notwithstanding, if you could see him, confer with him, and meet him face to face, you would triumph, either by force or persuasion, over that obstacle—the only serious one, the only insurmountable one, the only real one you met with on your road.’

‘All that is true, monsieur: my destiny, my future, my obscurity, or my glory depend upon that man; but what do you draw from that?’

‘One thing alone, that if this General Monk is troublesome to the point your majesty describes, it would be expedient to get rid of him or make an ally of him.’

‘Monsieur, a king who has neither army nor money, as you have heard my conversation with my brother Louis, has no means of acting against a man like Monk.’

‘Yes, sire, that was your opinion, I know very well: but, fortunately for you, it was not mine.’

‘What do you mean by that?’

‘That, without an army and without a million, I have done—I, myself—what your majesty thought could alone be done with an army and a million.’

‘How! What do you say? What have you done?’

‘What have I done? Eh! well, sire, I went yonder to take this man who is so troublesome to your majesty.’

‘In England?’

‘Exactly, sire.’

‘You went to take Monk in England?’

‘Should I by chance have done wrong, sire?’

‘In truth, you are mad, monsieur!’

‘Not the least in the world, sire.’

‘You have taken Monk?’

‘Yes, sire.’

‘Where?’

‘In the midst of his camp.’

The king trembled with impatience.

‘Not half an hour, your honour. My eldest son is at this moment preparing the boat, as we were going out fishing at three o’clock in the morning.’

‘Well, is all arranged?’ asked the king, drawing near.

‘All but the price,’ said the fisherman, ‘yes, sire.’

‘That is my affair,’ said Charles, ‘the gentleman is my friend.’

Monk started and looked at Charles on hearing this word.

‘Very well, my lord,’ replied Keyser. And at that moment they heard Keyser’s son, signaling from the shore with the blast of a bull’s horn.

‘Now, gentlemen,’ said the king, ‘depart.’

‘Sire,’ said D’Arragnan, ‘will it please your majesty to grant me a few minutes? I have engaged men, and I am going without them; I must give them notice.’

‘Whistle to them,’ said Charles, smiling.

D’Arragnan, accordingly, whistled, whilst the patron Keyser replied to his son; and four men, led by Menneville, attended the first summons.

‘Here is some money in account,’ said D’Arragnan, putting into their hands a purse containing two thousand five hundred livres in gold. ‘Go and wait for me at Calais, you know where.’ And D’Arragnan heaved a profound sigh, as he let the purse fall into the hands of Menneville.

‘What, are you leaving us?’ cried the men.

‘For a short time,’ said D’Arragnan, ‘or for a long time, who knows? But with 2,500 livres, and the 2,500 you have already received, you are paid according to our agreement. We are quits, then, my friend.’

‘But the boat?’

‘Do not trouble yourself about that.’

‘Our things are on board the felucca.’

‘Go and seek them, and then set off immediately.’

‘Yes, captain.’

D’Arragnan returned to Monk, saying,—‘Monsieur, I await your orders, for I understand we are to go together, unless my company be disagreeable to you.’

‘On the contrary, monsieur,’ said Monk.

‘Come, gentlemen, on board,’ cried Keyser’s son.

Charles bowed to the general with grace and dignity, saying,—‘You will pardon me this unfortunate accident, and the violence to which you

have been subjected, when you are convinced that I was not the cause of them.'

Monk bowed profoundly without replying. On his side, Charles affected not to say a word to D'Artagnan in private, but aloud,—'Once more, thanks, monsieur le chevalier,' said he, 'thanks for your services. They will be repaid you by the Lord God, who, I hope, reserves trials and troubles for me alone.'

Monk followed Keyser and his son embarked with them. D'Artagnan came after, muttering to himself,—'Poor Planchet! poor Planchet! I am very much afraid we have made a bad speculation.'

'From the king of France?'

'*Ma foi!* no, sire,' replied D'Artagnan. 'Your majesty must have seen yonder that the king of France is only occupied with his own majesty.' Charles raised his eyes towards heaven.

'No, sire, no,' continued D'Artagnan. 'I bring news entirely composed of personal facts. Nevertheless, I hope that your majesty will listen to the facts and news with some favour.'

'Speak, monsieur.'

'If I am not mistaken, sire, your majesty spoke a great deal at Blois, of the embarrassed state in which the affairs of England are.'

Charles coloured. 'Monsieur,' said he, 'it was to the king of France I related—'

'Oh! your majesty is mistaken,' said the musketeer, coolly; 'I know how to speak to kings in misfortune. It is only when they are in misfortune that they speak to me; once fortunate, they look upon me no more. I have, then, for your majesty, not only the greatest respect, but, still more, the most absolute devotion; and that, believe me, with me, sire, means something. Now, hearing your majesty complain of fate, I found that you were noble and generous, and bore misfortune well.'

'In truth!' said Charles, much astonished, 'I do not know which I ought to prefer, your freedoms or your respects.'

'You will choose presently, sire,' said D'Artagnan. 'Then your majesty complained to your brother, Louis XIV, of the difficulty you experienced in returning to England and regaining your throne for want of men and money.'

Charles allowed a movement of impatience to escape him.

'And the principal object your majesty found in your way,' continued D'Artagnan, 'was a certain general commanding the armies of the parliament, and who was playing yonder the part of another Cromwell. Did not your majesty say so?'

'Yes; but I repeat to you, monsieur, those words were for the king's ears alone.'

'And you will see, sire, that it is very fortunate that they fell into those of his lieutenant of musketeers. That man so troublesome to your majesty was one General Monk, I believe; did I not hear his name correctly, sire?'

'Yes, monsieur, but once more, to what purpose are all these questions.'

'*Mordieux!* then wake him. He won't scold you for having disturbed him, I will promise you.'

'You come on the part of the count, do you not?'

'The Comte de la Fère?'

'From Athos?'

'*Ma foi!* no, I come on my own part. Come, Parry, quick! The king—I want the king.'

Parry did not think it his duty to resist any longer; he knew D'Artagnan of old; he knew that, although a Gascon, his words never promised more than they could stand to. He crossed a court and a little garden, appeased the dog, that seemed most anxious to taste of the musketeer's flesh, and went to knock at the window of a chamber forming the ground-floor of a little pavilion. Immediately a little dog inhabiting that chamber replied to the great dog inhabiting the court.

'Poor king!' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'these are his body-guards. It is true he is not the worse guarded on that account.'

'What is wanted with me?' asked the king, from the back of the chamber.

'Sire, it is M. le Chevalier d'Artagnan, who brings you some news.'

A noise was immediately heard in the chamber; a door was opened, and a flood of light inundated the corridor and the garden. The king was working by the light of a lamp. Papers were lying about upon his desk, and he had commenced the first copy of a letter which showed, by the numerous erasures, the trouble he had had in writing it.

'Come in, monsieur le chevalier,' said he, turning around. Then perceiving the fisherman, 'What do you mean, Parry? Where is M. le Chevalier d'Artagnan?' asked Charles.

'He is before you, sire,' said M. d'Artagnan.

'What, in that costume?'

'Yes; look at me, sire; do you not remember having seen me at Blois, in the ante-chamber of King Louis XIV?'

'Yes, monsieur, and I remember I was much pleased with you.'

D'Artagnan bowed. 'It was my duty to behave as I did, the moment I knew that I had the honour of being near your majesty.'

'You bring me news, do you say?'

'Yes, sire.'

Chapter XXX

The Shares of Planchet and Company rise again to Par



URING the passage, Monk only spoke to D'Artagnan in cases of urgent necessity. Thus, when the Frenchman hesitated to come and take his meals, poor meals, composed of salt fish, biscuit, and Hollands gin, Monk called him, saying,—'To table, monsieur, to table!'

This was all. D'Artagnan, from being himself on all great occasions, extremely concise, did not draw from the general's conciseness a favourable augury of the result of his mission. Now, as D'Artagnan had plenty of time for reflection, he battered his brains during this time in endeavouring to find out how Athos had seen King Charles, how he had conspired his departure with him, and lastly, how he had entered Monk's camp; and the poor lieutenant of musketeers plucked a hair from his moustache every time that he reflected that the horseman who accompanied Monk on the night of the famous abduction must have been Athos.

At length, after a passage of two nights and two days, the patron Keyser touched at the point where Monk, who had given all the orders during the voyage, had commanded they should land. It was exactly at the mouth of the little river, near where Athos had chosen his abode.

Daylight was waning; a splendid sun, like a red steel buckler, was plunging the lower extremity of its disc beneath the blue line of the sea. The felucca was making fair way up the river, tolerably wide in that part, but Monk, in his impatience, desired to be landed, and Keyser's boat set him and D'Artagnan upon the muddy bank, amidst the reeds. D'Artagnan, resigned to obedience, followed Monk exactly as a chained bear

follows his master; but the position humiliated him not a little, and he grumbled to himself that the service of kings was a bitter one, and that the best of them was good for nothing. Monk walked with long and hasty strides; it might be thought that he did not yet feel certain of having reached English land. They had already begun to perceive distinctly a few of the cottages of the sailors and fishermen spread over the little quay of this humble port, when, all at once, D'Arragnan cried out, — 'God pardon me, there is a house on fire!'

Monk raised his eyes, and perceived there was, in fact, a house which the flames were beginning to devour. It had begun at a little shed belonging to the house, the roof of which had caught. The fresh evening breeze agitated the fire. The two travellers quickened their steps, hearing loud cries, and seeing, as they drew nearer, soldiers with their glittering arms pointed towards the house on fire. It was doubtless this menacing occupation which had made them neglect to signal the felucca. Monk stopped short for an instant, and, for the first time, formulated his thoughts into words. 'Eh! but,' said he, 'perhaps they are not my soldiers but Lambert's.'

These words contained at once a sorrow, and apprehension, and a reproach perfectly intelligible to D'Arragnan. In fact, during the general's absence, Lambert might have given battle, conquered, and dispersed the parliament's army, and taken with his own the place of Monk's army, deprived of its strongest support. At this doubt, which passed from the mind of Monk to his own, D'Arragnan reasoned in this manner: — 'One of two things is going to happen; either Monk has spoken correctly, and there are no longer any but Lambertists in the country—that is to say, enemies, who would receive me wonderfully well, since it is to me they owe their victory; or nothing is changed, and Monk, transported with joy at finding his camp still in the same place, will not prove too severe in his settlement with me.' Whilst thinking thus, the two travellers advanced, and began to mingle with a little knot of sailors, who looked on with sorrow at the burning house, but did not dare to say anything on account of the threats of the soldiers. Monk addressed one of these sailors: — 'What is going on here?' asked he.

'Sir,' replied the man, not recognizing Monk as an officer, under the thick cloak which enveloped him, 'that house was inhabited by a foreign gentleman, and this foreigner became suspected by the soldiers. They

'I don't like to declare my name in the open air, either; besides, you may be sure I shall not eat your dog, and I hope to God he will be as reserved with respect to me.'

'You bring news, perhaps, monsieur, do you not?' replied the voice, patient and querulous as that of an old man.

'I will answer for it, I bring you news you little expect. Open the door, then, if you please, hein!'

'Monsieur,' persisted the old man, 'do you believe, upon your soul and conscience, that your news is worth waking the king?'

'For God's sake, my dear monsieur, draw your bolts; you will not be sorry, I swear, for the trouble it will give you. I am worth my weight in gold, parole d'honneur!'

'Monsieur, I cannot open the door till you have told me your name.'

'Must I, then?'

'It is by the order of my master, monsieur.'

'Well, my name is—but, I warn you, my name will tell you absolutely nothing.'

'Never mind, tell it, notwithstanding.'

'Well, I am the Chevalier d'Arragnan.'

The voice uttered an exclamation.

'Oh! good heavens!' said a voice on the other side of the door. 'Monsieur d'Arragnan. What happiness! I could not help thinking I knew that voice.'

'Humph!' said D'Arragnan. 'My voice is known here! That's flattering.'

'Oh! yes, we know it,' said the old man, drawing the bolts, 'and here is the proof.' And at these words he let in D'Arragnan, who, by the light of the lantern he carried in his hand, recognized his obstinate interlocutor.

'Ah! *Mordieu!*' cried he: 'why, it is Parry! I ought to have known that.'

'Parry, yes, my dear Monsieur d'Arragnan, it is I. What joy to see you once again!'

'You are right there, what joy!' said D'Arragnan, pressing the old man's hand. 'There, now you'll go and inform the king, will you not?'

'But the king is asleep, my dear monsieur.'